regiment of nuclear-armed cruise missiles to attack the base in the event of war. Guantánamo Bay might now be remembered as the place where nuclear war between the United States and the Soviet Union broke out – assuming there were survivors of that war to do any remembering.

During the first half of the twentieth century US economic control of the Cuban economy grew. Estimates suggest that by the 1950s US companies owned forty per cent of the Cuban sugar industry, eighty per cent of Cuban utilities, and ninety per cent of Cuba's mining industry.[9] US corporations were an important factor in US foreign policy in Central and South America. The United Fruit Company, for example, was a powerful lobbyist for intervention in Guatemala, when, in 1954, a CIA-organised coup toppled the democratically elected leftist government of Jacobo Arbenz.

By the 1950s Havana was used by American visitors as a holiday weekend destination. Many availed themselves of the local casinos and brothels. What would now be described as sex tourism flourished, nurtured by the Mafia, who monopolised Havana's gambling, drugs and prostitution enterprises. In December 1957 Senator John F. Kennedy made the first of two visits to Havana, when, during a period of marital difficulties, he enjoyed what Michael Beschloss describes as 'a bachelor's holiday'.[10] The Senator was not, in fact, enamoured of casinos, preferred legal to illegal drugs (to treat his chronic back problems), and had no interest in brothels (given his carnal appetites were otherwise satiated).

While JFK was enjoying his bachelor's weekend in Havana, Fidel Castro was fighting a guerrilla war against the army of President Fulgencio Batista. Castro's road to power followed years of armed struggle. On 26 July 1953 he led a group of some 160 men and women in an attack on the Moncada barracks in Santiago de Cuba to procure weapons for the revolution. The attack failed. Many of those captured were tortured and murdered. Castro narrowly avoided their fate but was sentenced to fifteen years in prison (after he delivered a four-hour oration in his defence). 'History will absolve me,'he famously wrote.[11] Had Batista's court acted towards Castro as Castro's revolutionary tribunals acted towards Batista's followers (with widespread executions), then while History might have absolved Fidel, it most likely would not have remembered him very much. Instead, he was